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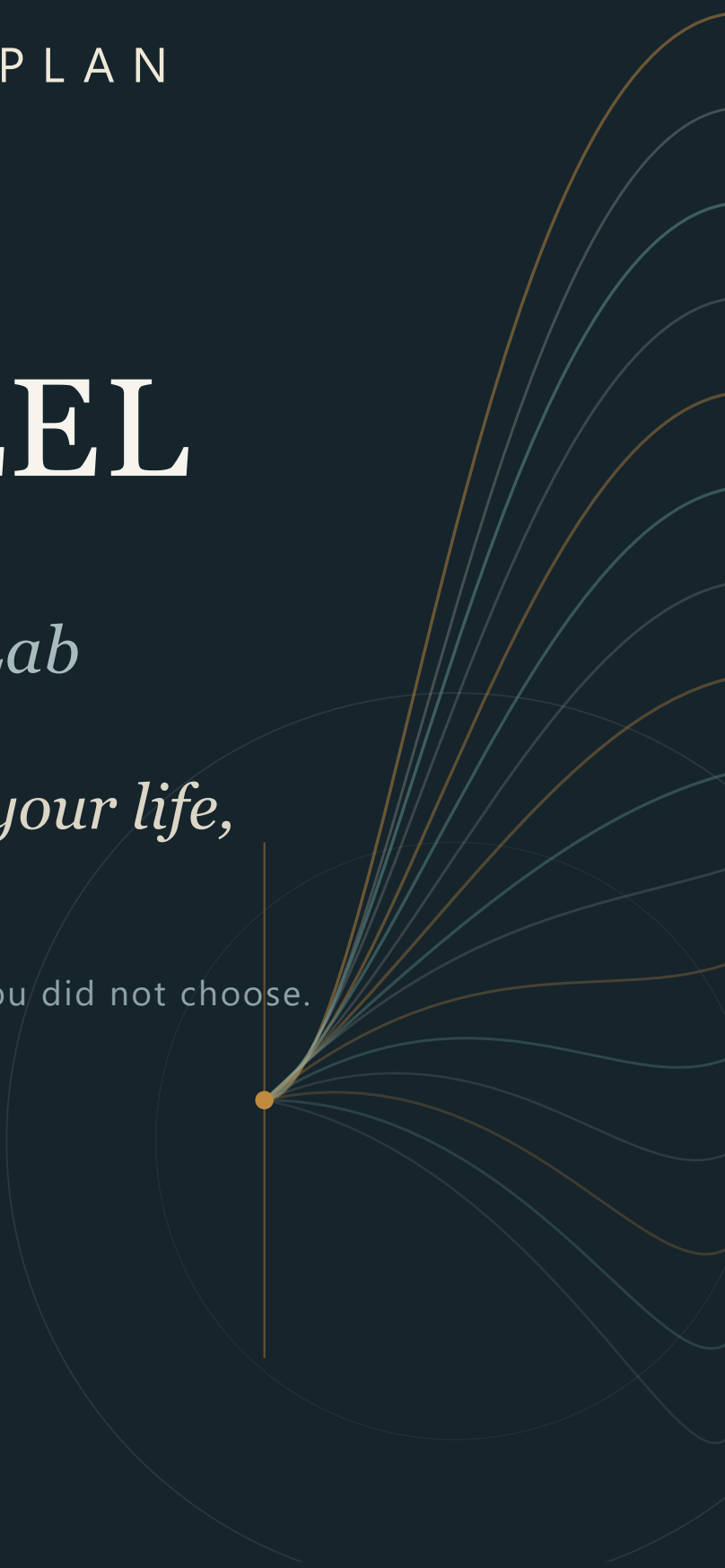
APP BUSINESS PLAN

PARALLEL ME

Life Exploration Lab

Before you change your life, try another one.

A rehearsal space for the life you did not choose.



MOBILE APP DEVELOPMENT · AUTUMN 2026

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DOCUMENT INFORMATION

Parallel Me

LIFE EXPLORATION LAB · APP BUSINESS PLAN · PHASE 1

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A mobile app that helps adults test a possible life before they change the one they have.

This document sets out the product, the market, the business model and the validation plan for the first phase of the project. Each section closes with the decision it supports.

Sources are listed in Appendix C. Figures and tables are the team's own unless otherwise stated.

Prepared by Team 11 · Mobile App Development · Autumn 2026. Product names and trademarks remain the property of their owners.

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“Before you change your life, try another one.”

The proposition in one line. The plan explains what it would take to make it true.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The life you did not choose

Parallel Me is a mobile app for adults who have built a life that works and still wonder about the one they did not choose. It turns a recurring thought into a structured rehearsal: name the unfinished self, test two or three plausible futures, observe a real working life, then run the smallest possible experiment.

Most products in this space help people *manage* the life they have. Productivity tools optimise the calendar; coaching apps improve performance; meditation apps calm the mind; course platforms add skills. None of them answers the question that surfaces at 23:10 on a Tuesday: *what would that other life actually be like?*

The product answers it with a four-layer loop. **The Unfinished Self** surfaces ambitions that were postponed. **Life Rehearsal** turns one of them into two or three scenarios with visible trade-offs. **Borrow My Life** lets a user observe a screened host's real routine. **Parallel Life Mission** converts the insight into a 24-hour, three-day or seven-day experiment, followed by a structured reflection and a decision.

The beachhead is UK adults aged 40–55 who can name a deferred ambition, with midlife women as the sharpest entry point. The model is freemium: a free first loop, then £8.99 per month for deeper scenarios, history and guided missions. At a 3% paid conversion, break-even is roughly 16,800 monthly active users, which is a realistic three-year target rather than a first-quarter one.

Phase 1 asks a single question: **does the loop change what someone does next?** We will answer it with 12–15 interviews, a clickable prototype tested with 5–8 users, and a 20-person seven-day mission pilot. The decision gates are fixed in advance. The marketplace is deliberately excluded until screening, consent, insurance and incident processes exist.

> Advice is cheap. Evidence is personal.

AT A GLANCE

BEACHHEAD
UK adults 40–55 with a deferred ambition

CORE LOOP
Reflect → rehearse → observe → experiment

MODEL
Freemium · £8.99 / month

BREAK-EVEN
≈ 16,800 MAU at 3% paid

90-DAY TEST
15 interviews · 8 usability tests · 20 missions

PHASE 1 DECISION
Build the digital loop. Defer the marketplace.

PART I · THE OPPORTUNITY

The Possibility Gap

Most people do not need another plan for the life they have. They need a low-risk way to find out what another one would actually feel like.

At 23:10 on a Tuesday, a 47-year-old middle manager closes a spreadsheet and opens a tab she has opened before: a travel-writing course she has never booked. She is not unhappy. She has a job, a family and a calendar that works. What she has lost is not happiness but *possibility*: the sense that the person who once wanted to write could still exist.

1.1 The gap is not motivation. It is evidence.

Adults in midlife are unusually good at managing constraints and unusually bad at testing desires. They can list the reasons not to change: school fees, a mortgage, a team that depends on them, the risk of starting again. What they cannot do is answer the only question that would make the decision easier: *what would that life actually be like, and would I still want it?*

Existing products answer adjacent questions. Productivity tools help someone do more of what they already do. Coaching apps improve how they perform. Meditation apps reduce the stress of the life they have. Course platforms add a skill but not an identity. Social platforms show other people's lives without letting anyone test one. The gap is a **safe, structured rehearsal** that connects reflection to a real experience and ends in a decision.

> **THE INSIGHT THIS PLAN IS BUILT ON**
>
> People do not lack advice. They lack personal evidence. A seven-day experiment that costs £30 and can be reversed is more persuasive than a year of reading about a different life. The product's job is to design that experiment, not to recommend the outcome.

1.2 Why now

Three shifts make a rehearsal product viable in 2026 in a way it was not five years ago. They are not predictions; they are conditions the product can use.

FIGURE 1 Three shifts make rehearsal possible now

01
Simulation becomes cheap

A personalised scenario now costs pennies of inference, not an hour of a coach's time. The constraint moves from access to design quality.

02
Midlife becomes a design phase

Longer working lives, later caring responsibilities and second careers push "what else?" into the 40s and 50s, not retirement.

03
People buy proof, not content

Spending is shifting from things to experiences. A seven-day test is more convincing than another online course.

Context signal: 43% of adults aged 35–54 in OECD countries took part in adult learning in the previous 12 months, eight percentage points below the 25–34 group. Constraints are real; the desire to explore is not the bottleneck.

Source: OECD Education Policy Outlook 2025, "Mid-Career" [2]. The statistic measures learning participation, not demand for Parallel Me.

The argument is not that the market is large. It is that the cost of giving someone a realistic preview has fallen below the cost of a single coaching session.

1.3 The product thesis

If evidence is the bottleneck, the product should behave less like a library and more like a laboratory. That produces five design principles, and they constrain every feature decision that follows.

- **Agency over advice.** The app never says which life is better. It shows trade-offs and asks the user to decide.
- **Reversibility.** Every experiment is small enough to stop. A 24-hour mission can be abandoned without a career consequence.
- **Specificity.** "Explore your creativity" is not a mission. "Write 1,500 words before work for five days and publish one piece" is.
- **Evidence over engagement.** Success is a decision the user can defend, including the decision to change nothing. Time-in-app is not the goal.
- **Consent by design.** Reflection is intimate. Users choose what is saved, and can delete it.

43%
adult-learning participation, ages 35–54, OECD average

8pp
gap versus the 25–34 group; mid-career is where flexibility falls

1 question
the product exists to answer: what would that life actually be like?

The rest of the plan follows from these principles: evidence over engagement, reversibility over commitment, and a first build narrow enough to test with twenty people.

PART II · THE PRODUCT

The Four-Layer Product

Parallel Me is one loop in four movements: remember what was postponed, imagine what it would require, observe what it is really like, and test the smallest version of it.

2.1 What it is, and what it is not

Parallel Me is an AI-supported life-exploration app for adults who want to examine an alternative life before making a consequential decision. It combines guided reflection, scenario modelling, real-world observation and short experiments, then returns the user to a structured reflection.

It is **not** a mental-health treatment, a social network, a generic AI assistant or a productivity tool. AI generates and stress-tests scenarios; it does not diagnose, predict or prescribe. The boundary matters commercially as well as ethically: it keeps the product out of clinical regulation and out of the crowded "AI coach" category.

> **PRODUCT BOUNDARY**
>
> The app may help someone decide to leave a job, but it must never tell them to. Every scenario is labelled as a possibility, every assumption is visible, and the user can correct or delete the model's output.

The product's unit of value is a decision, not a session. A user might spend eight minutes in the first conversation and seven days in a mission, then not open the app again for a month. That is a success if the decision was useful. It is a failure if the app produced insight but no change in what the user did next.

That definition has a commercial consequence. The product cannot rely on daily engagement, streaks or notifications to create value; it has to be worth returning to at the moments when a decision is close. It also explains why the app is deliberately narrow: a general-purpose life assistant would compete with everything and earn permission for nothing.

The boundary is also a safety decision. Reflection can surface regret, family conflict or financial anxiety. The app is designed to hold those questions without pretending to treat them: it offers structure, not therapy, and it signposts professional support when a user's needs go beyond exploration.

The product is not a one-off assessment. A single report about "your ideal life" would be easy to produce and easy to ignore. The loop is designed to be revisited: a user can return with a new ambition, a different constraint or a decision that has become urgent.

This is why the first release is deliberately smaller than the vision. The digital loop can be built and tested in one semester; the real-world layer requires screening, insurance and incident processes that a small team cannot improvise. The product earns the right to the marketplace by proving the loop first.

The name matters here. "Parallel Me" is not a metaphor for a fantasy self; it is a way to describe a real alternative that could be tested. The product's language avoids promises of transformation and uses the vocabulary of experiments: a hypothesis, a trial, a result, a decision.

2.2 The four layers

The layers are not features in a menu. They are stages of one argument, and each produces an artefact the next stage needs. A user can stop after any layer and still receive something useful: a named ambition, a comparison, an observation, or a decision.

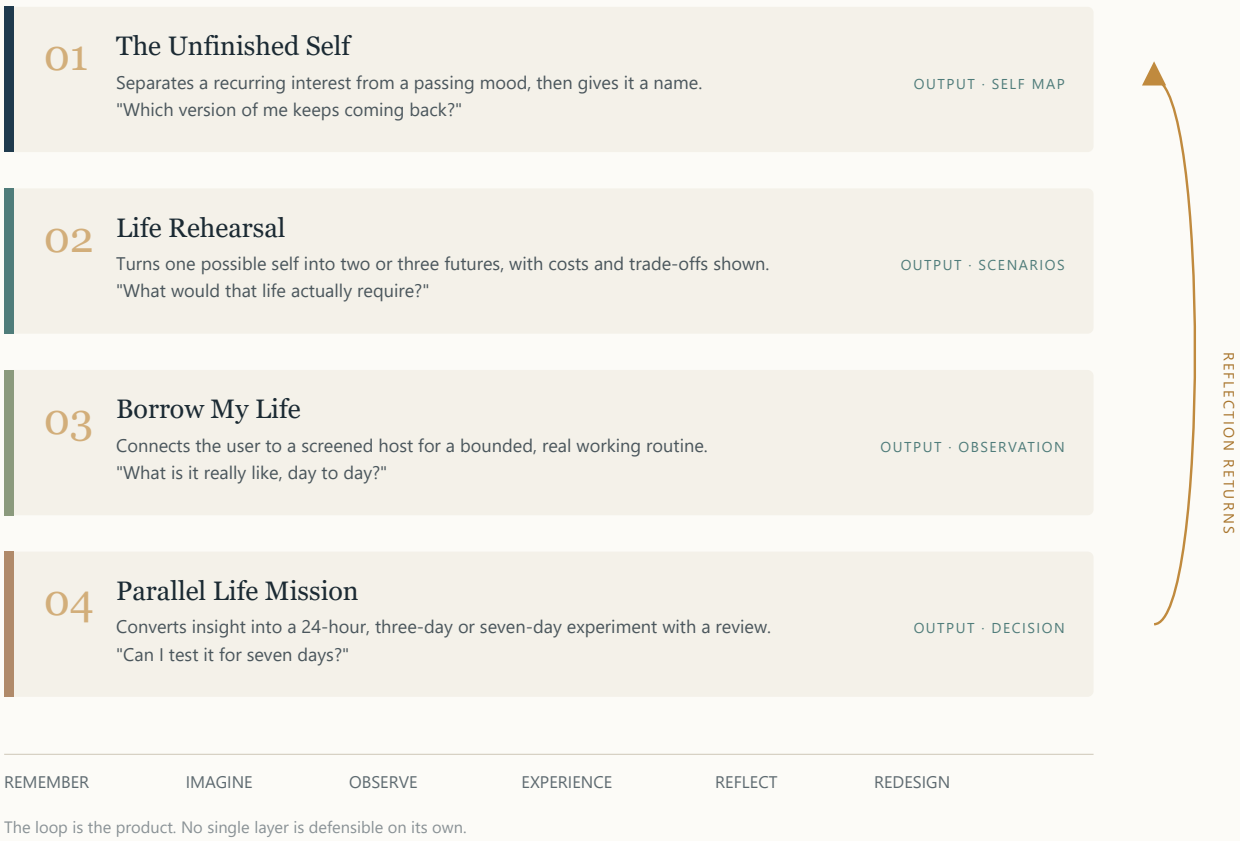
Read the figure from top to bottom. Layer 1 answers "which version of me keeps coming back?" and produces a map. Layer 2 answers "what would that life actually require?" and produces two or three scenarios. Layer 3 answers "what is it really like, day to day?" and produces an observation. Layer 4 answers "can I test it for seven days?" and produces a decision.

The order is not arbitrary. A scenario built before the user has named the ambition becomes generic; an observation offered before a scenario has no question to answer; an experiment designed before an observation is a guess. Each layer narrows the uncertainty the next one has to resolve.

The loop closes with reflection, not with a recommendation. The user records what felt real, what was novelty and what was effort, and the app uses that record to revise the map. This is why the product is a system rather than a feature: the value is in the sequence, and the sequence is what a competitor would have to copy.

Every artefact is editable. The user can rename a possible self, change a scenario assumption or delete a reflection. Control is not a settings page; it is part of the product's argument that the user, not the model, owns the decision.

FIGURE 2 One loop, four layers, four artefacts



The loop is the product. No single layer is defensible on its own.

Layer 3 is deliberately gated. It appears in the vision but not in the first build; see the MVP decision in 2.5.

2.3 The journey

The loop is designed to be completed in one sitting, then repeated over weeks. The first session takes about eight minutes and ends with a map; the experiment takes seven days and ends with a decision. The two moments of truth are the map (does it feel personal?) and the reflection (did anything change?).

The eight steps fall into three phases. Steps 1-3 help the user understand what is being postponed; steps 4-6 help them test it; steps 7-8 help them decide. The phases are sequential, but the loop is designed to be re-entered at any point.

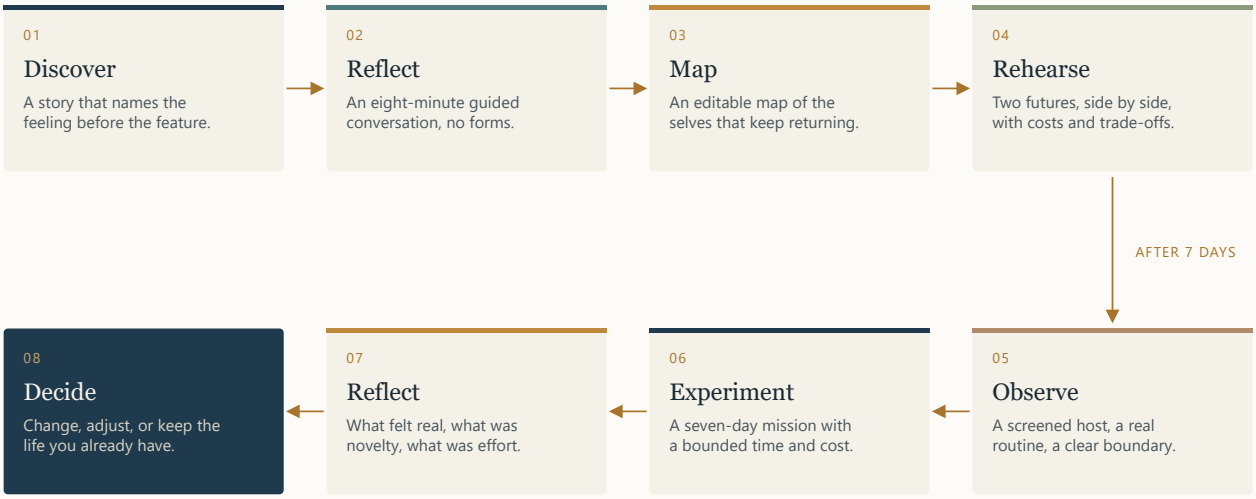
The first moment of truth is the map. If the map feels like a horoscope, the user stops. It has to use the user's own language, include at least one uncomfortable detail and allow immediate correction.

The second moment of truth is the reflection after the experiment. A pleasant week is not evidence; the app has to help the user separate novelty from a life they would choose again. That is why the reflection asks what was difficult, what was boring and what they would repeat.

The journey also defines the analytics. The team tracks completion at each step, the time between the map and the first mission, and the proportion of users who return to reflect. A drop at step 3 is a product problem; a drop at step 7 is a mission-design problem.

- **Never ask for more than the next step requires.** The first session should end before the user is tired of it.
- **Make every step reversible, including the decision to stop.** A user can leave with a map and no mission.
- **Show what changed, not how long they stayed.** Completion and decisions matter more than time in app.

FIGURE 3 Eight steps, two moments of truth



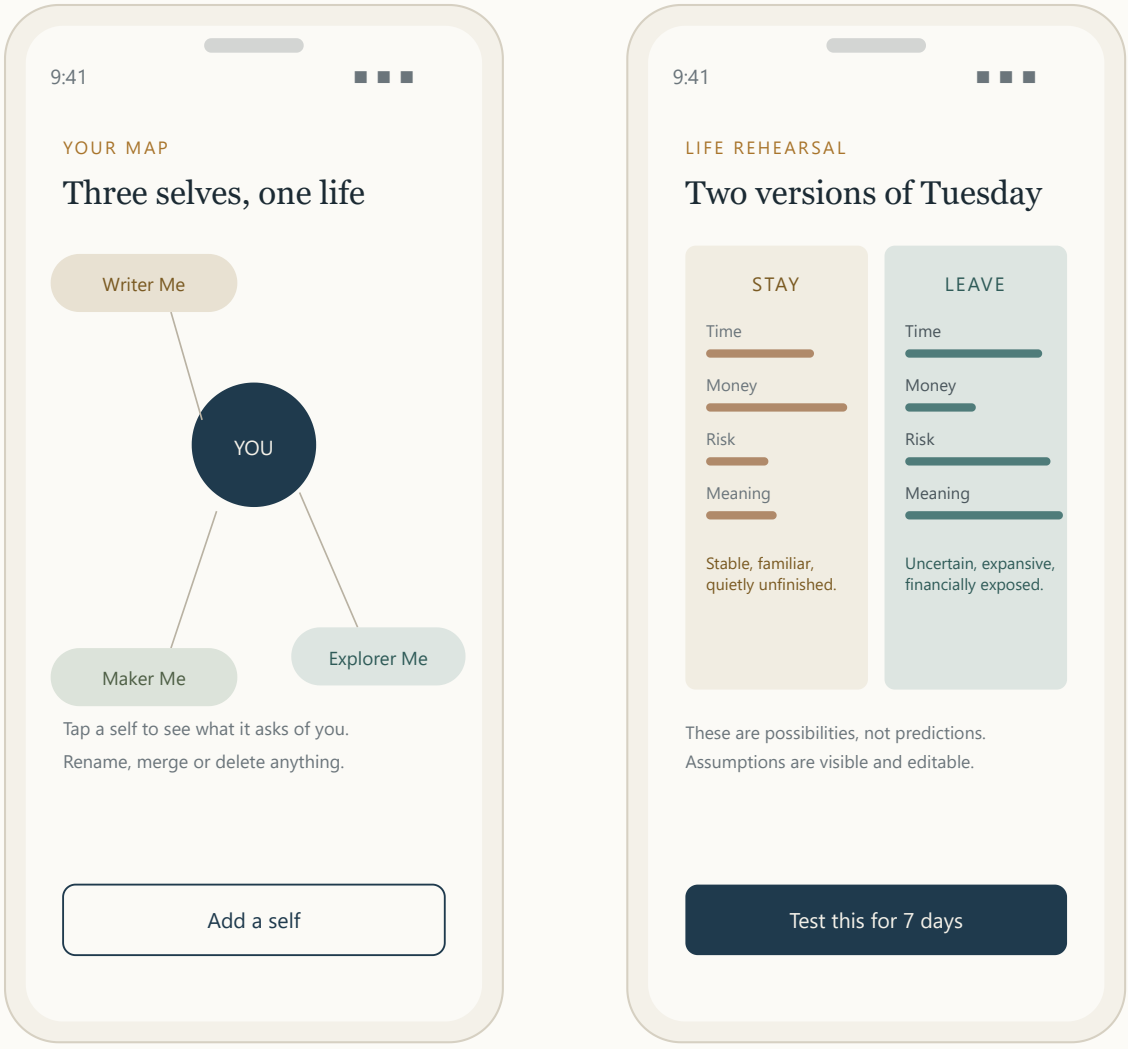
MOMENT OF TRUTH 01 · step 03: does the map feel personal, or like a horoscope?
MOMENT OF TRUTH 02 · step 07: did the experiment produce evidence, or only a nice week?

The journey is deliberately short. A user who stops at step 03 still leaves with a named ambition and a map.

2.4 The first session, on screen

The interface has to do something difficult: ask intimate questions without feeling like a form, and show a possible future without implying a prediction. The design answer is a conversation, a map and a comparison, in that order.

FIGURE 4 Two screens that carry the first loop



THE SELF MAP REHEARSAL

A first-session prototype in the product's own visual language. Not final UI.

2.5 What we build first

The full vision is operationally heavy. A small team cannot screen hosts, arrange insurance and run an incident process in one semester, and a first release that tried would be both unsafe and unconvincing. The MVP therefore proves the digital loop first.

FIGURE 5 Now, next, later: the scope is a sequence, not a wish list



The boundary is a safety decision, not a lack of ambition. Layer 3 is the most distinctive part of the vision and the easiest way to harm a user.

MVP FEATURE	PHASE	ACCEPTANCE CRITERION
Guided self-discovery conversation	Now	A first-time user names at least one meaningful possible self without a facilitator.
Editable Unfinished Self Map	Now	The user can rename, merge, delete and export every node; nothing is saved without consent.
Two-scenario rehearsal	Now	Each scenario shows time, money, risk and meaning, with its assumptions visible.
Seven-day mission planner	Now	A user converts one insight into a bounded experiment with a start date and a stop rule.
Structured reflection	Now	The user records what felt real, what was novelty and what they would repeat.
Subscription tier	Next	Tested only after repeat use is observed; price shown as a concrete offer, not a survey question.
Borrow My Life pilot	Later	Ten screened hosts, written scope, insurance review, incident pathway and a named safeguarding lead.

Table 1. MVP scope and acceptance criteria. The first build deliberately excludes the marketplace.

NON-GOALS

- Diagnosing or treating a mental-health condition, or replacing professional support.
- Predicting which life will make a user happy, or recommending a resignation, divorce or investment.
- Monetising intimate reflections through advertising or unrelated model training.
- Launching an open person-to-person marketplace before screening, consent and insurance exist.

PART II · THE PRODUCT

The Proposition

The product is not competing with coaching, meditation or courses. It is competing with the years someone spends wondering, and with the market's habit of selling advice instead of evidence.

3.1 The unique selling proposition

UNIQUE SELLING PROPOSITION

For adults who keep returning to a life they did not choose, Parallel Me is the only app that turns that thought into a series of low-risk rehearsals, so they can test a possible self in the real world before they bet their current life on it.

The statement contains four commitments, and each one is testable. **Only app** is a claim about the integration of reflection, scenarios, observation and experiments, not about any single feature. **Turns that thought into rehearsals** is the mechanism. **Low-risk** is the promise. **Before they bet their life** is the moment of purchase: the product is valuable when a decision is close, not when someone is merely curious.

3.2 The enemy is optimisation, not boredom

A proposition becomes memorable when it has an enemy. Ours is not a competitor; it is a default assumption in the category. Most self-improvement products assume the user's job is to become more effective at the life they already have. They optimise sleep, focus, habits, skills and productivity. That assumption is useful, and it is also the reason the original question never gets answered.

THE CATEGORY DEFAULT

"Here are the tools to do what you already do, better. Here is a course to add a skill. Here is a coach to improve your performance. Here is a meditation to make the current life more bearable."

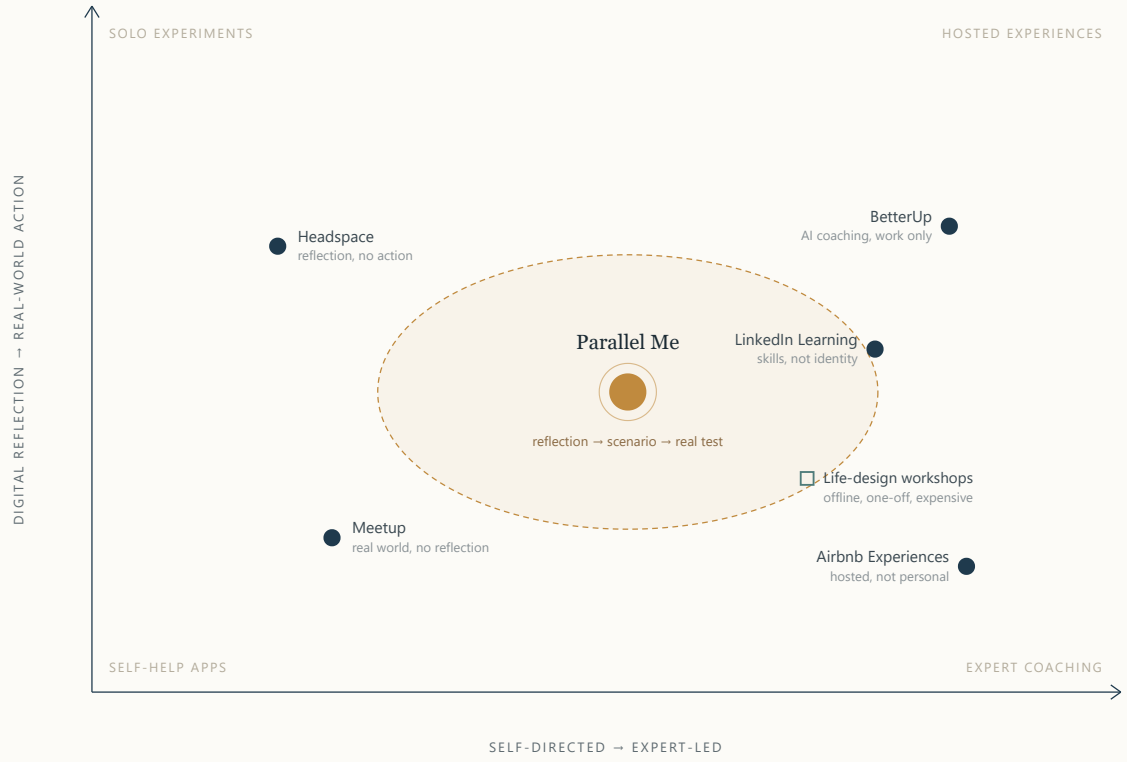
PARALLEL ME

"Here is a way to find out what the other life would actually require, what it would feel like on a Tuesday, and whether you still want it. Then decide, including the decision to change nothing."

3.3 Where the product sits

Plotting the adjacent products reveals the space Parallel Me is trying to occupy. Most products are either digital and self-directed (meditation, courses) or real-world and expert-led (hosted experiences). The centre, a guided loop that moves between reflection and real life, is thin. It is thin because it is operationally hard, not because nobody has thought of it.

FIGURE 6 The gap is the loop between digital reflection and real-world proof



Positioning is a desk assessment of public product descriptions [4]–[8], not a feature audit. Life-design workshops are shown as a category.

The empty centre is the strategic bet. It is also the hardest place to operate, which is why the plan phases the real-world layer.

3.4 Why the position can be defended

AI is not the moat. Any competitor can call a model. The defensible assets are the things that make the loop trustworthy and repeatable.

- **The loop, not the model.** A single scenario is easy to copy; the sequence from memory to experiment to reflection is a product system with switching costs.
- **Trust as a feature.** Intimate reflection requires consent, deletion and restraint. A brand that can prove this earns permission a growth-driven app cannot.
- **Mission design and partner supply.** A library of small, safe experiments improves with every cohort; screened hosts and creative communities are slow to build, which makes them a barrier once built.

What would prove us wrong. A proposition is only useful if it can fail. Three findings would force a rethink: users call it "a nicer journal" and never finish a mission; the scenarios feel generic enough that nobody pays; or only the real-world layer matters, which would make it an experience marketplace.

PART II · THE PRODUCT

Who It Is For

The product is for the person who can already name the life she did not choose. Not for someone looking for a hobby, and not for someone in crisis.

4.1 The beachhead

The first segment is **UK adults aged 40–55 who can name a deferred ambition**, with midlife women as the sharpest entry point because the project brief identifies them and because the constraints are concentrated: caring responsibilities, a settled career, financial commitments and a shrinking sense of optionality. The product remains open to any adult in a transition, but marketing and research start here.

Two boundaries keep the segment honest. It is defined by a *need state*, not by age alone: the person must be able to name something they have postponed. And it is not a claim that all midlife women share one experience. The persona below is a design scenario, not evidence of demand.

4.2 Persona: Linda

L

Linda, 47

MIDDLE MANAGER · TWO CHILDREN · ABERDEEN

"I don't want to blow up my life. I want to know if the writing thing is real, or just a story I tell myself."

GOALS

- Find out whether writing is a real interest or a fantasy.
- Keep her job and family stable while she tests it.
- Make a decision she can defend to herself.

FRUSTRATIONS

- Courses that assume she has five free evenings a week.
- Advice that jumps from "follow your passion" to "quit your job".
- Apps that ask for her deepest thoughts before earning trust.

WHERE SHE IS REACHABLE

- Creative-writing newsletters and local writing groups.
- Midlife-career communities and women's professional networks.
- Search: "career change at 47", "start writing again".

WHAT SHE WOULD PAY FOR

- A structured seven-day test with a clear outcome.
- One honest conversation with someone who lives the life.
- Not another content library. Not a streak.

Persona derived from the project brief [P1]; illustrative, not validated research. Age, role and city are design choices, not survey findings.

4.3 A day in her life

The product has to fit moments, not demographics. Linda's day contains four moments where the need appears, and each one maps to a different product entry point.

06:40	13:10	21:30	23:10
Phone in hand before the house wakes. Reads a newsletter about a writing residency.	Lunch at her desk. Searches "can you start writing at 47" and closes the tab.	Children settled. Opens a course page, checks the price, adds to a list she never revisits.	In bed, the thought returns: "What if I had kept writing?"
PAIN · aspiration with no next step	PAIN · advice that does not fit her constraints	PAIN · another library, no evidence	PAIN · the decision never gets made

Figure 7. The persona and the moments that matter. The product is designed for 06:40 and 23:10, not for a generic "user session".

4.4 Secondary segments and anti-persona

SEGMENT	NEED STATE	ROLE IN THE PLAN
Primary · midlife deferred ambition	Can name a postponed creative, career or lifestyle ambition; wants proof before change.	All Phase 1 research and the first campaign.
Secondary · mid-career explorer	Considering a new professional identity but cannot leave a job to test it.	Second cohort; tests whether scenarios generalise beyond creative work.
Secondary · post-caregiving	Children more independent, or caring role ending; wants to rebuild a self.	Partnership channel; strong emotional fit.
Anti-persona · clinical need	Depression, anxiety, crisis or bereavement requiring professional care.	Out of scope. Signpost, never substitute.
Anti-persona · productivity seeker	Wants a better system for the current life, not to examine an alternative.	Out of scope. High churn risk, wrong promise.

Table 2. Segment priorities. The anti-personas protect both users and the business model.

4.5 Jobs to be done

- When I keep returning to a path I never tried, help me understand what that desire is really asking for.
- When a change feels too risky, help me compare two honest versions of the next five years.
- When I cannot tell whether I like the idea or the reality, let me observe or test it safely.
- After the test, help me decide what to change, what to keep, and what to stop wondering about.

PART III · THE MARKET

Market Analysis

Parallel Me does not sit inside an established category, so a category-size number would be fiction. The defensible approach is a need-based funnel with visible assumptions, tested against a specific segment.

5.1 Category and sizing logic

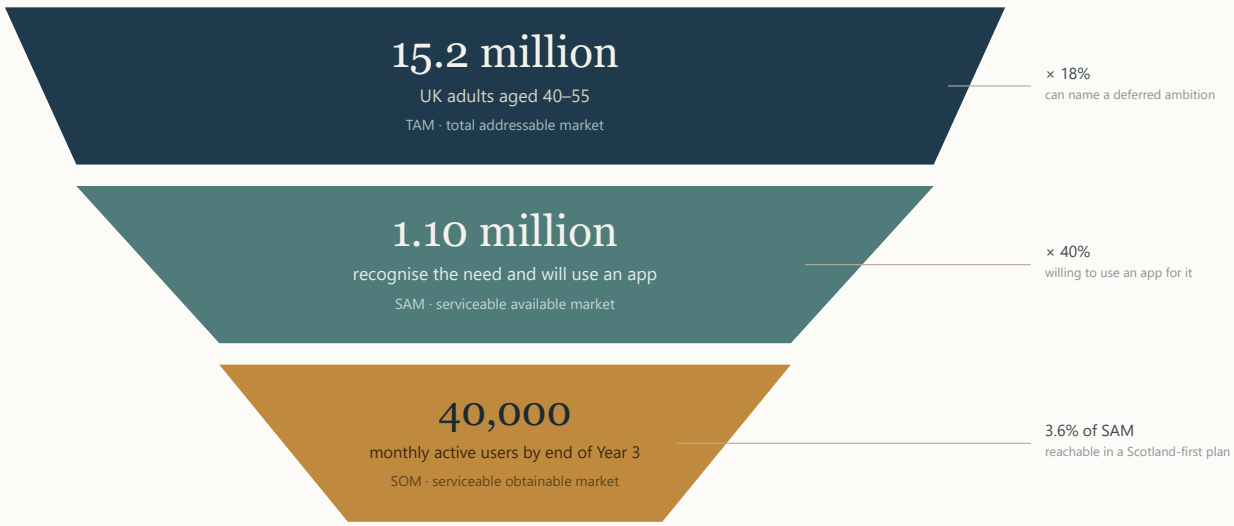
The product borrows from four adjacent categories: self-improvement apps, career and life coaching, experience marketplaces, and adult learning. Each is large, and each would produce a misleading market size. The wellness-app market includes people buying sleep sounds; the experience market includes hen parties; the coaching market includes corporate leadership programmes. None of those buyers is necessarily looking for a life rehearsal.

We therefore size the market from the need outward. The question is not "how large is the wellness market?" but "how many UK adults in the beachhead could plausibly recognise this need, reach the app, and pay for it?" That produces a smaller number and a more useful one.

5.2 TAM, SAM and SOM

The model has three steps and one explicit conversion between each. Population comes from published age structure; the two behavioural rates are planning assumptions to be tested in Phase 1. The arithmetic is shown in Appendix B so a reader can change any input.

FIGURE 8 A need-based funnel, not a category-size claim



Population base: ONS mid-2024 age structure, England scaled to the UK; derivation in Appendix B [11]. The two conversion rates are planning assumptions, not survey findings. A generic wellness-market figure would overstate the opportunity by an order of magnitude.

The SOM is a three-year target consistent with the base case in Section 9, not a first-year forecast.

15.2m
adults aged 40–55 in the UK

1.10m
need + app-reachable, the serviceable market

40k
MAU by Year 3, 3.6% of the serviceable market

Two sanity checks matter more than the precision of the numbers. First, the funnel implies that roughly one in twenty-eight app-reachable users would need to become an active user by Year 3, which is ambitious but not implausible for a focused UK launch. Second, if the 18% need rate is wrong by half, the SAM falls to about 550,000 and the three-year target becomes 7% of it. That is the assumption the first research phase must test. Scotland, the proposed pilot geography, had a population of 5,545,500 at mid-2025 [3]; the pilot's reachable base is deliberately a small fraction of the UK funnel, not a national claim.

5.3 Competitive landscape

Five adjacent products and one offline category were reviewed. None is a direct competitor, which is both an opportunity and a warning: the absence of a direct competitor can mean an unmet need, or a need that is not strong enough to support a product.

PRODUCT / CATEGORY	GUIDED REFLECTION	AI SCENARIOS	STRUCTURED MISSIONS	REAL-WORLD ACCESS	REFLECTION LOG	COMMUNITY	SELF-SERVE PURCHASE
BetterUp AI Coach [4]	●	○	●	○	●	○	○
Headspace [5]	●	○	○	○	●	○	●
LinkedIn Learning [6]	○	○	●	○	●	●	●
Meetup [7]	○	○	○	●	○	●	●
Airbnb Experiences [8]	○	○	○	●	○	●	●
Life-design workshops (category)	●	○	●	●	●	●	○
Parallel Me	●	●	●	●	●	●	●

Figure 9. Feature comparison based on public product pages [4]–[8] and a category-level assessment of life-design workshops. Dots indicate full, partial or no coverage; they are not a quality judgement.

Three observations shape the strategy. **Digital players have no real world**: Headspace, BetterUp and LinkedIn Learning can support reflection, but none of them can put a user in someone else's working day. **Real-world players have no reflective layer**: Meetup and Airbnb Experiences can supply an activity, but they do not help a user choose one or interpret it afterwards. **Nobody closes the loop**: the closest analogue is an offline life-design workshop, which is one-off, expensive and unavailable to most of the segment.

The absence of a direct competitor is not proof of demand. It may mean the integration is hard to operate, which is exactly the risk the MVP is designed to test. It may also mean users are satisfied with the combination of a journal, a course and a conversation, in which case the product must be clearly better than that bundle rather than merely more integrated.

5.4 SWOT into strategy

A SWOT list is not analysis until it produces a choice. The TOWS below converts each combination into a decision the team can act on this semester.

FIGURE 10 From SWOT to four strategic choices

SO · STRENGTHS × OPPORTUNITIES

Use the narrative and creative-community partners to launch a content-led "try before you change" series. The story is the acquisition channel, not an ad budget.

WO · WEAKNESSES × OPPORTUNITIES

No brand and a small team: deliver the first fifty missions by hand with partner communities and concierge onboarding, then automate what works.

ST · STRENGTHS × THREATS

Turn privacy and safety into visible proof. Publish the data policy, show the delete flow, and make governance a reason to trust the product.

WT · WEAKNESSES × THREATS

Do not build the marketplace. Stay digital-first until unit economics and safeguarding are proven, even if the vision is broader.

Strengths: a coherent loop and a distinctive story. Weaknesses: unproven demand, no brand, a small team. Opportunities: adjacent categories are unbundled. Threats: easy feature copying, sensitive data, unsafe real-world experiences.

5.5 What must be true

The market case rests on four conditions. If any one fails, the plan changes materially.

- **The need is recurring, not nostalgic.** At least 8 of 12–15 interviewees describe a deferred ambition that recurs without prompting.
- **The loop is understood in one sentence.** At least 4 of 5 testers can explain it back after a short introduction.
- **The experiment produces evidence.** At least 70% of the pilot cohort can name a specific learning or next step.
- **Someone pays.** A concrete offer converts, not a hypothetical "would you pay?".

PART IV · THE PLAN

The Business Model

A free first loop earns the right to ask for money. The paid product is depth and continuity, never access to safety or privacy.

6.1 How value becomes revenue

The model is freemium with a subscription at £8.99 per month. The free tier includes the guided conversation, one editable self map and one scenario comparison, because the product must demonstrate the loop before asking for a card. The paid tier adds deeper scenarios, saved history, guided mission planning and a structured review. A commission on curated experiences is a later option, not part of this plan's economics.

Three rules protect the model. Safety features are never paywalled. Personal reflections are never sold or used for advertising. The free tier must be useful on its own; a deliberately crippled free product would damage the trust the paid product depends on.

6.2 The model on one page

KEY PARTNERS

Creative-writing and midlife-career communities. Adult-learning organisations. Screened host providers, later. Privacy and legal advisers.

KEY ACTIVITIES

Prompt and scenario design. Mission design. AI output evaluation. Partner recruitment.

KEY RESOURCES

The loop design. The mission library. Trust brand. Cohort data.

VALUE PROPOSITION

Test a possible life for seven days before you change the one you have. A guided, reversible loop that produces personal evidence rather than advice.

CUSTOMER RELATIONSHIPS

Guided onboarding. Concierge support for the first cohort. Opt-in community. No streak pressure, no guilt mechanics.

CUSTOMER SEGMENTS

UK adults 40–55 with a deferred ambition; midlife women first. Secondary: mid-career explorers, post-caregiving adults.

COST STRUCTURE

AI inference · design and content · support · hosting · legal and privacy review · marketing. Safeguarding and insurance only when the real-world layer opens.

REVENUE STREAMS

£8.99 monthly subscription. Annual plan later. Curated experience commission later. No advertising, no data sales.

Figure 11. Business Model Canvas. The left side is designed to be lean; the right side depends on trust.

6.3 Pricing

The price is a hypothesis anchored to the value of a decision, not to competitors. £8.99 is roughly the price of a paperback, and less than a single hour of coaching. It is deliberately low enough to be an impulse for the beachhead and high enough to fund AI inference, support and content.

- **£6.99** · the volume test. Lower friction, thinner margin, useful if conversion is the constraint.
- **£8.99** · the base case. Contribution per paying subscriber of about £3.97 after store fees and the cost of serving the free cohort.
- **£12.99** · the value test. Viable only if the scenario and mission depth is clearly superior.

Pricing will be tested with concrete offers: a real paywall at the end of the second scenario, not a survey question. The test measures selection and cancellation, not stated willingness to pay.

6.4 Cost structure

COST DRIVER	TYPE	PLANNING ASSUMPTION
AI inference and hosting	Variable	£0.08 per monthly active user, assuming cached prompts, a small model for routine turns, and encrypted storage.
Content and mission design	Fixed	£700 per month for a designer and a content lead, part-time.
Support and moderation	Variable	£0.03 per monthly active user; higher in the first cohort because onboarding is concierge.
Legal, privacy and insurance	Fixed	£400 per month from launch; a step change when the real-world layer opens.
Tools and analytics	Fixed	£300 per month for design software, analytics, accounting and hosting tooling.
Marketing	Planned	£600 per month, consistent with the £1,800 90-day budget in Section 7.

Table 3. Cost drivers at pilot scale. Figures are planning estimates, not quotes.

At 1,000 monthly active users the variable cost is about £110 per month, dominated by inference. That is deliberately conservative: AI costs are falling, but a product that depends on a price decline is not a business. The model must work at today's inference prices.

6.5 Unit economics

CONTRIBUTION PER ACTIVE USER

At 3% conversion, each monthly active user generates £0.23 of net revenue after the 15% store fee. Variable cost is £0.11 (AI, hosting, support), leaving **£0.12 of contribution**. With fixed costs of £2,000 per month, break-even is about **16,800 MAU**. At 5% conversion contribution rises to £0.27 and break-even falls to about 7,350 MAU; at 2% it rises to about 46,700 MAU. In subscriber terms, the 3% case needs roughly 500 paying users. A 1,000-user pilot cannot break even, and should not try to; its job is to prove retention, not to cover fixed costs.

PART IV · THE PLAN

Go-to-Market

This is not a product that scales on paid social. It scales on a story that people recognise, delivered through communities that already have permission to talk about midlife.

7.1 Strategy

The launch has three moves. **Content earns recognition**: essays and short exercises that name the feeling before the feature. **Partners borrow trust**: writing, career and midlife communities already speak to the segment and can host a workshop or a newsletter edition. **Concierge delivery earns evidence**: the first fifty missions are supported by hand, because the team needs to see where people stop, not just how many click.

Paid social is included only as a controlled test. It is useful for measuring the hook and the cost of a qualified visit; it is not the growth engine, and the funnel below shows why.

7.2 Channels

CHANNEL	ROLE	FIRST 90 DAYS	METRIC
Content and search	Capture existing intent: "career change at 47", "start writing again".	Six essays, two worksheets, one landing page per intent.	Organic visits, sign-up rate, scroll depth.
Partner newsletters	Borrow trust from communities the segment already reads.	Three co-branded editions with writing and career communities.	Clicks, interviews recruited, cost per sign-up.
Live workshops	Demonstrate the loop in 45 minutes; recruit the pilot.	Four online sessions, twelve to twenty people each.	Attendance, mission starts, referrals.
Paid social (test)	Measure the hook and the cost of a qualified visit.	£600 over six weeks, two creative routes, one audience.	CAC, qualified-visit rate, activation.
Referral	Convert a completed mission into a warm introduction.	£10 credit after a verified reflection.	Referral rate, referred activation.

Table 4. Channel roles and 90-day activity. No channel is scaled before its activation rate is known.

7.3 The funnel and the unit-economics warning

The 90-day plan assumes £1,800 of total marketing spend. The funnel is deliberately modest, because the goal is learning rather than volume.

FIGURE 12 A pilot funnel that pays for learning, not growth



Blended CAC: £1,800 ÷ 13 = £138. LTV: £3.97 × 9 months = £36. LTV / CAC = 0.26.
Paid acquisition does not pay back at pilot scale. It validates the hook; partners and content must carry growth.

Conversion rates are planning assumptions. The strategic conclusion is robust to moderate error: at these price points, paid social cannot fund acquisition.

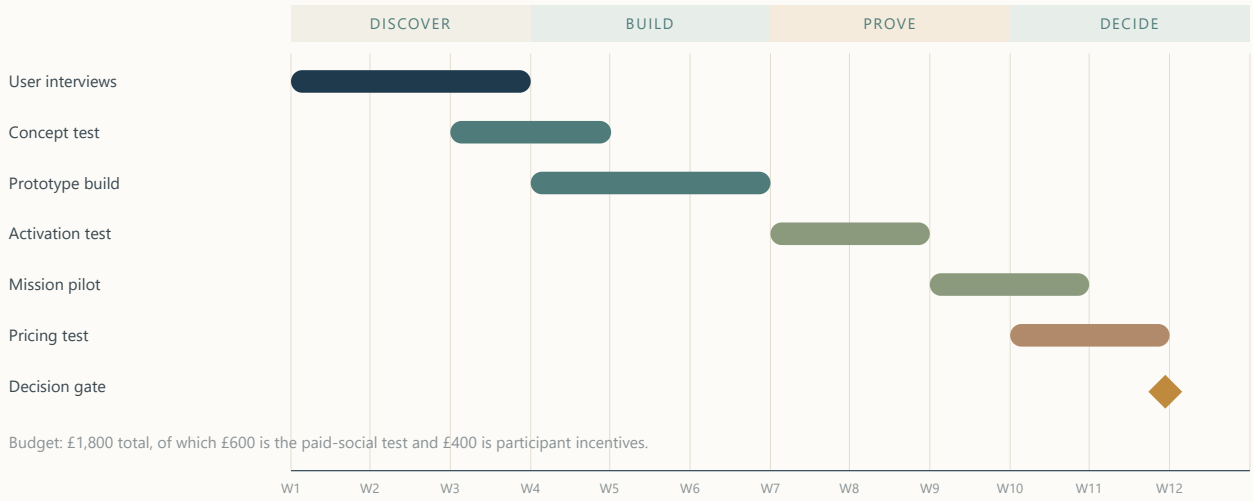
This is the most important commercial finding in the plan. A £138 CAC against a £36 LTV means the product cannot buy growth. It must earn distribution through partners, search and referral, or raise the price, or increase lifetime value through a longer subscription. The 90-day test is designed to measure which of those is possible before any money is spent at scale.

7.4 Marketing principles

- Lead with the user's question, not the technology. Never open with "AI-powered".
- Use real quotes only with written consent. Never invent a testimonial or a case study.
- Make privacy and the "no major change required" promise visible on the landing page.
- Do not buy keywords that imply therapy, diagnosis or crisis support.
- Measure activation and mission completion, not impressions.

7.5 The first 90 days

FIGURE 13 Twelve weeks, three phases, one decision



Each phase produces a document, not just an opinion: a problem statement and revised persona after week 4; a tested prototype and a usability findings log after week 8; a cohort dataset and a go/no-go recommendation after week 12. The gate is a team decision with pre-agreed thresholds, not a conversation held after seeing the data.

PART IV · THE PLAN

Validation Plan

The plan is designed to be killed cheaply. Five experiments, each with a pre-committed threshold, decide whether the next phase is worth funding.

8.1 Three questions, not eight

Validation frameworks become useful when they are reduced to the questions that can change the plan. We use three: **desirability** (do users recognise the need and want the loop?), **feasibility** (can we deliver it safely and repeatably?), and **viability** (will enough users pay enough to sustain it?). Each experiment below answers one of them.

DESIRABILITY

Is the need real, recurring and strong enough to act on? Does the loop feel personal?

FEASIBILITY

Can a small team build the digital loop, and can the real-world layer be delivered safely later?

VIABILITY

Will users return, and will a concrete offer convert at a price that covers cost?

8.2 The five experiments

EXPERIMENT	SAMPLE	WHAT IT ANSWERS	THRESHOLD TO CONTINUE
Problem interviews	12–15, primary segment	Does the deferred ambition recur without prompting? What do they use today?	8 of 12–15 describe a recurring ambition and an unsolved gap.
Concept test	30–50 survey, 8 interviews	Is the loop understood, and is it meaningfully different from a journal plus a course?	4 of 5 can explain it back; 60% rank it above their current alternative.
Usability test	5–8 per iteration	Where do users stop, misunderstand, or refuse to share?	60% complete the first loop without a facilitator.
Mission pilot	20 opt-in users	Do users finish a seven-day mission and return to reflect?	50% complete; 70% of completers name a specific next step.
Pricing test	Pilot cohort	Does a concrete offer convert, and at which price?	At least 6% of activated users choose a paid plan or join a paid waitlist with a deposit.

Table 5. Experiments and thresholds. Thresholds are team decision rules for an exploratory pilot, not industry benchmarks.

RESEARCH ETHICS

Interviews touch on identity, family and regret. Participants are told the purpose, can skip any question, and can withdraw their data. Quotes are anonymised and used only with written consent. No interviewee is asked to describe a mental-health condition, and any disclosure of crisis is met with signposting rather than product positioning.

8.3 Decision gates

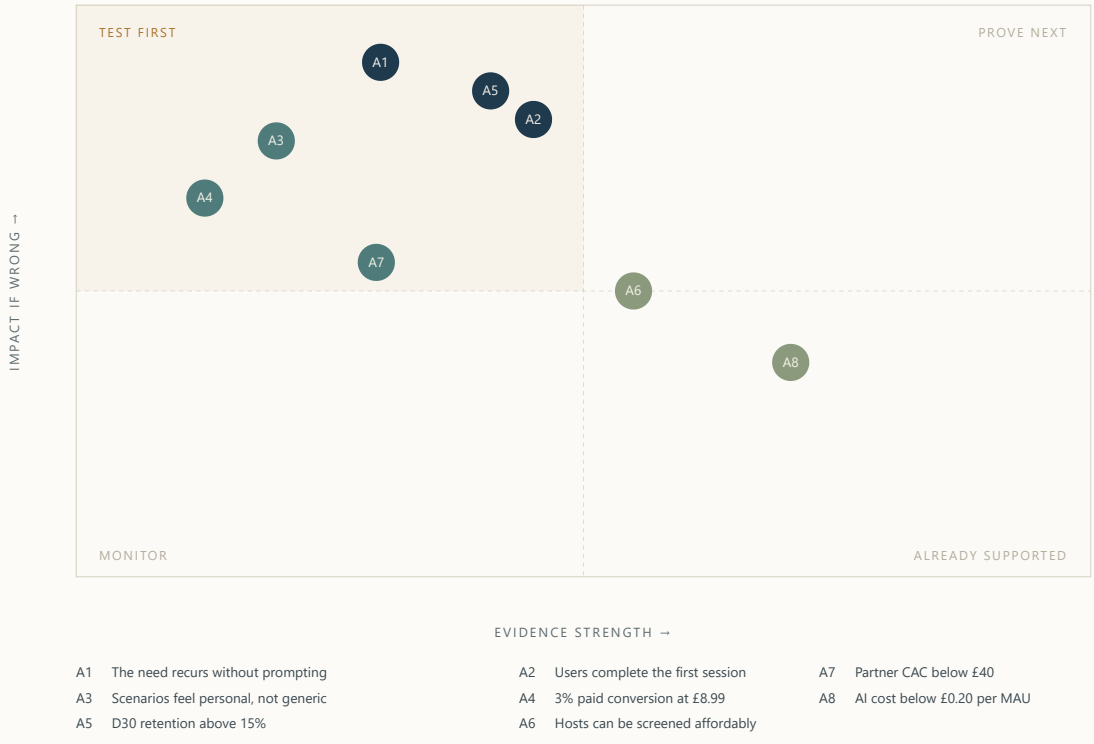
GATE	EVIDENCE REQUIRED	IF NOT MET
Problem signal	8 of 12–15 interviewees name a recurring deferred ambition without being led.	Reframe the segment or the problem; do not build.
Comprehension	4 of 5 testers explain the loop in their own words.	Simplify the proposition and onboarding.
Activation	60% complete the first loop unaided.	Reduce scope; fix the map and the first prompt.
Perceived value	70% of completers name a specific learning or next step.	Redesign the mission and the reflection.
Repeat use	30% return to reflect within 30 days.	Reconsider retention before spending on acquisition.
Paid intent	6% of activated users choose a paid plan or place a deposit.	Change price, packaging or segment; do not scale.

Table 6. Decision gates. They are fixed before data collection to prevent post-hoc reinterpretation.

8.4 The assumption map

Not every assumption deserves the same attention. The map below plots each one by the strength of existing evidence and the impact if it is wrong. The test-first quadrant is the research agenda.

FIGURE 14 Test the assumptions that are both weak and consequential



PART V · DELIVERY

The Numbers

The financial plan is deliberately small and deliberately explicit. It shows what has to be true for the product to sustain itself, and what would make the team stop.

9.1 The metrics that matter

Nine metrics describe the business. Vanity metrics such as downloads, impressions and time-in-app are excluded because none of them predicts whether a user will pay or return.

METRIC	DEFINITION	WHAT IT TESTS
Activation rate	Users completing the first loop ÷ users starting onboarding.	Whether the first value is reachable.
D7 / D30 retention	Users active on day 7 or 30 ÷ the starting cohort, with a fixed cohort rule.	Whether value persists beyond novelty.
Mission completion	Missions completed ÷ missions started.	Whether missions are realistic and well scoped.
Paid conversion	Paying users ÷ eligible active users in the period.	Whether the paid tier is worth its price.
CAC	Acquisition spend ÷ new paying customers attributed to it.	Whether a channel can scale economically.
Contribution margin	(Revenue − variable cost) ÷ revenue.	Whether growth funds itself.
LTV	Contribution per subscriber × observed months retained.	Sustainability, only after cohort data exist.
Trust and safety	Reportable incidents, complaints, consent withdrawals, deletion completion.	Whether the product is safe to operate.
Equity of outcome	Completion and value ratings by age, gender and access needs.	Whether the product works beyond one narrow user.

Table 7. Metric definitions. Denominators and cohort windows are fixed before data collection.

9.2 Sensitivity

Two variables dominate the model: how many people use the app and how many pay. The table shows monthly contribution after variable cost, against a fixed-cost line of £2,000.

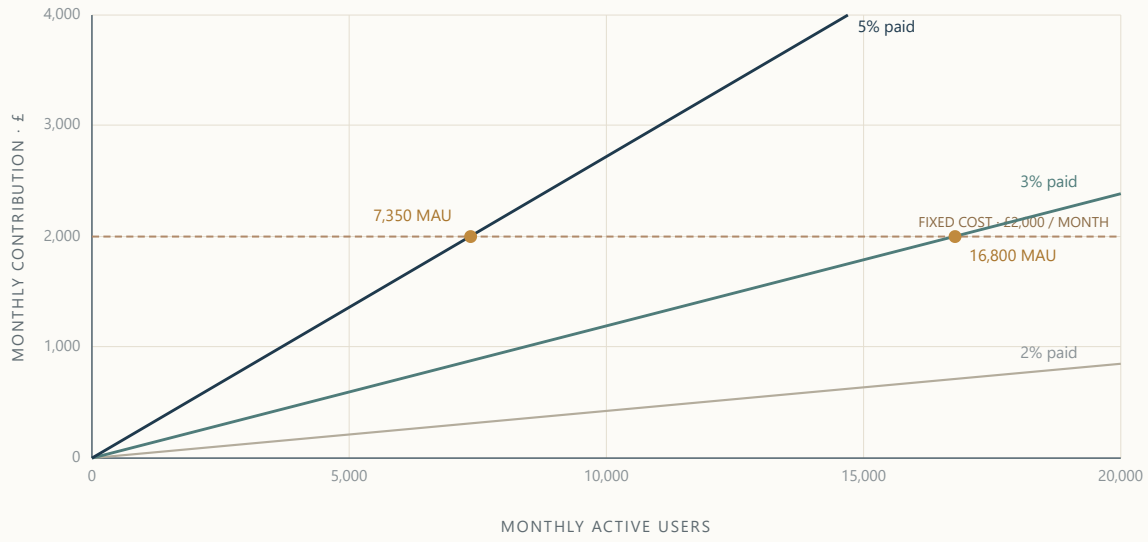
MONTHLY ACTIVE USERS	2% PAID	3% PAID (BASE)	5% PAID
1,000	£43	£119	£272
5,000	£214	£596	£1,360
17,000	£728	£2,027	£4,625
40,000	£1,713	£4,770	£10,883

Figure 15. Monthly contribution after the 15% store fee and £0.11 variable cost per MAU. Shaded cells exceed the £2,000 fixed-cost line. Gross revenue before store fees is roughly 2.3× these figures at 3% conversion.

The base case breaks even at about 16,800 MAU. That is not a small number for a first product, and it is not a large number for a UK consumer app with a real niche. The critical insight is the shape of the table: at 2% conversion, even 40,000 users produce only £1,713 of monthly contribution, which is below fixed cost. Conversion matters more than reach.

9.3 Break-even

FIGURE 16 Break-even moves from 7,350 to 46,700 users as conversion falls



Contribution = MAU × conversion × £8.99 × 0.85 − MAU × £0.11. Store fees are inside the calculation. Lines are planning scenarios, not forecasts.

9.4 Stop rules

- If paid conversion stays below 2% after two price tests, stop the subscription and test a one-off paid mission instead.
- If mission completion stays below 40%, stop acquisition and redesign the mission before spending more.
- If blended CAC exceeds £80 after six months, stop paid acquisition permanently.
- If a serious safety incident occurs in any real-world pilot, pause the layer until the process is independently reviewed.

9.5 Three-year base case

The base case assumes a Scotland-first launch, partner-led acquisition and a slow improvement in conversion as the mission library matures. Founder salaries are excluded, as is standard at this stage.

YEAR	EXIT MAU	PAID CONVERSION	PAYING USERS	GROSS REVENUE	CONTRIBUTION	FIXED COSTS	OPERATING CONTRIBUTION
Y1	2,000	3.0%	60	£6,470	£2,860	£24,000	−£21,140
Y2	12,000	4.0%	480	£51,780	£28,180	£24,000	+£4,180
Y3	40,000	5.0%	2,000	£215,760	£130,600	£24,000	+£106,600

Table 8. Annualised exit run-rate, not average revenue. Excludes founder time, corporation tax and any experience commissions.

The shape is more important than the totals. Year 1 loses money by design; Year 2 is approximately break-even; Year 3 produces a clearly positive operating contribution. A plan showing a profit in Year 1 would be less credible.

PART V · DELIVERY

Feasibility and Team

The digital loop is buildable in one semester. The marketplace is not. The plan is credible because it says which is which.

10.1 What can actually be built

AREA	FEASIBILITY	ASSESSMENT AND IMPLICATION
Guided reflection and self map	High	A guided prompt flow and an editable node map are achievable in four to six weeks with a small team. Build first.
AI scenario generation	Medium	Feasible with templates, structured outputs and visible assumptions. The risk is generic language and false certainty, not the model.
Mission planning and reflection	High	Checklists, reminders and a reflection form are simple. The design challenge is making missions specific and reversible.
Real-world host exchange	Low in semester 1	Requires screening, identity checks, insurance, safeguarding, cancellations and incident response. Defer to Year 1–2.
Subscription and payments	Medium	Store billing is straightforward; the hard part is the paywall design and the price test.

Table 9. Feasibility by area. The assessment is about the team's capacity, not about long-term ambition.

10.2 Team and division of work

Three roles cover the semester. Each role has a named owner, a deliverable and a weekly cadence.

ROLE	OWNER	RESPONSIBILITY IN PHASE 1
Product, research and growth	吴沛熹	Interview guide, recruitment, synthesis, persona revision, usability sessions, partner outreach and the 90-day channel test.
Design and front-end	何锦鹏	Design system, clickable prototype, the three first-session screens, accessibility.
AI, back-end and data	李俊	Prompt design, scenario templates, data model, encryption, deletion flow, analytics.

Table 10. Roles and ownership. Safeguarding advice is brought in before any real-world pilot.

Two capability gaps are acknowledged. Legal and privacy review requires an adviser; the plan budgets £400 per month for it. Safeguarding requires someone with operational experience of vulnerable adults; we will appoint an adviser before the controlled pilot, not after. The team cannot improvise either.

10.3 Roadmap

The roadmap is a sequence of evidence, not a list of features. Each stage produces a document, a dataset or a decision, and each gate can stop the next stage before more money is spent.

FIGURE 17 Five stages, five gates, eight months



Each gate can stop the next stage. The roadmap buys evidence, not activity.
A failed gate is a result: it narrows the next bet.

The first two stages can be delivered with the current team. The controlled pilot requires a safeguarding adviser and an insurance review, which is why it sits after the beta rather than alongside it.

PART V · DELIVERY

Risk and Governance

This product asks people to describe what they regret. That makes trust a product requirement, not a communications exercise.

11.1 The risk map

Risks are plotted by likelihood and impact. The two in the top-right cell, retention and unsafe host interaction, are the ones that can end the business rather than slow it down.

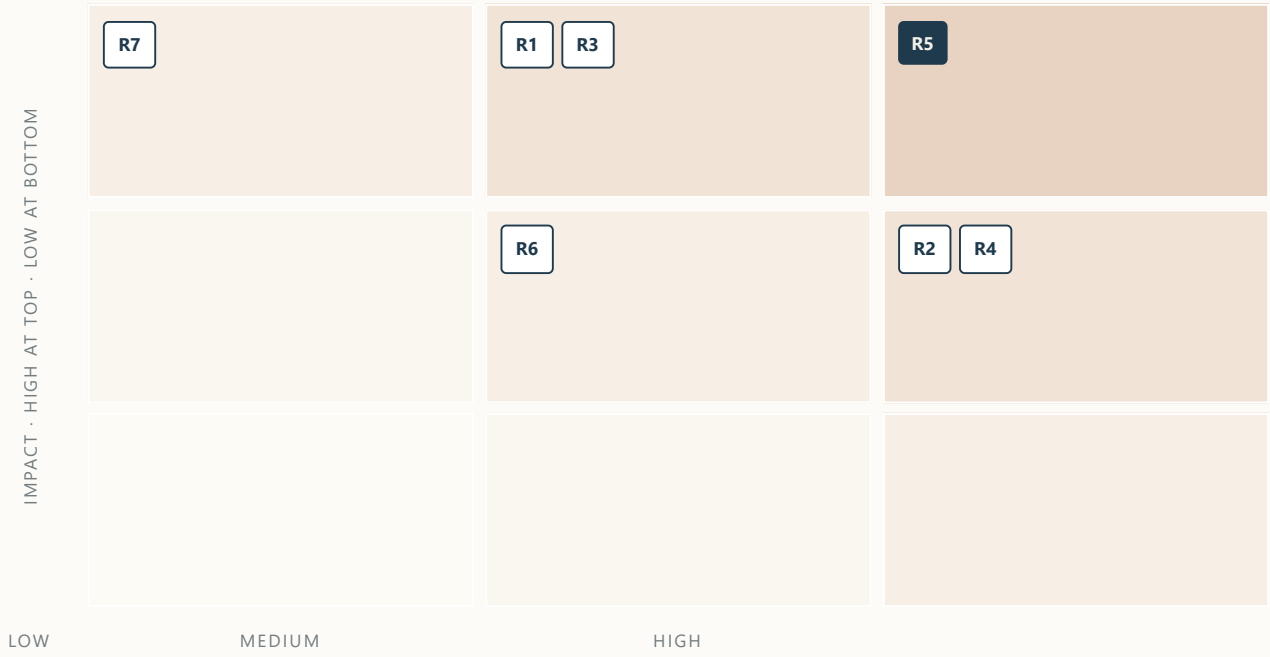


Figure 18. Risk heat map. Likelihood increases left to right; impact increases bottom to top. R5 is the most dangerous combination.

ID	RISK	POTENTIAL IMPACT	MITIGATION
R1	Sensitive reflection data exposed	Loss of trust, embarrassment, discrimination.	Collect only what is needed; encrypt in transit and at rest; define retention and deletion; review vendors.
R2	AI overconfidence or inaccurate scenarios	A user treats a possibility as a prediction and makes a high-stakes decision.	Label scenarios as possibilities; show assumptions; invite corrections; never direct a resignation, divorce or investment.
R3	Unsafe host interaction	Harassment, injury, exploitation or a power imbalance.	Screen hosts, verify identity, define scope in writing, meet in appropriate settings, insure, and run an incident process.
R4	Willingness to pay is weaker than assumed	Conversion below 2%; break-even moves out of reach.	Test concrete offers early; keep the cost base low; be ready to sell a one-off mission instead of a subscription.
R5	Retention collapses after the first mission	LTV falls below CAC; growth becomes uneconomic.	Design a second mission before launch; measure D30; stop acquisition until repeat use is proven.
R6	Marketplace operations cost more than expected	Support, refunds and insurance erase the commission.	Keep the marketplace manual and small; model host payout, refunds and support separately before scaling.
R7	Regulatory or platform-policy change	Data or health-adjacent claims trigger additional obligations.	Stay outside clinical claims; follow UK GDPR and ICO guidance; review store policies before launch.

Table 11. Risk register. Owned by the product lead and reviewed at every stage gate.

11.2 Trust commitments

- Plain-language consent before any sensitive reflection is collected, with a visible skip option.
- Users can edit, export and delete their map and reflections; deletion is completed within a stated period.
- No use of intimate reflection data for advertising or unrelated model training.
- AI-generated content is labelled as AI-assisted and open to correction.
- Real-world experiences are opt-in, bounded and supported by a documented safety process.
- A visible route exists for complaints, incident reports and data requests.

11.3 Regulatory context

Parallel Me processes personal data about identity, family, work and aspirations. The UK Information Commissioner's Office sets out how data-protection principles apply to AI systems, including lawfulness, fairness, transparency, purpose limitation, data minimisation, accuracy, storage limitation, security and accountability [9]. UK government guidance adds privacy by design and by default [10]. The precise obligations depend on the final data flows, providers and jurisdiction; this section is a design checklist, not legal advice.

The product also stays deliberately outside clinical claims. It does not diagnose, treat or promise a mental-health outcome. That boundary reduces regulatory exposure and, more importantly, avoids promising something the product cannot deliver.

PART V · DELIVERY

Conclusion

Parallel Me is a small product with a large question behind it: can someone test a life before betting another one on it?

The concept is coherent. Four layers form one loop, each layer produces an artefact the next one needs, and the loop ends in a decision rather than in more content. The proposition is distinctive because it competes with the years people spend wondering, not with a single app category. The market is large enough to matter and narrow enough to test: 1.1 million app-reachable adults in the UK, with a three-year target of 40,000 monthly users.

The commercial logic is honest. At £8.99 and a 3% conversion, the product needs about 16,800 monthly users to break even, and paid acquisition does not pay back at pilot scale. That is not a reason to abandon the idea; it is a reason to build distribution through communities, content and partners, and to keep the cost base deliberately small. The plan's most valuable financial output is not the revenue line. It is the knowledge that conversion matters more than reach.

The biggest risk is not competition. It is that the product becomes a beautiful journal that nobody returns to. The second biggest is that the real-world layer, which makes the concept distinctive, is launched before it can be delivered safely. Both risks are addressed by the same discipline: a narrow digital MVP, pre-committed gates, and a marketplace that waits until screening, insurance and incident processes exist.

WHAT PHASE 1 MUST PROVE

That the need recurs, that the map feels personal, that a seven-day mission produces a decision, and that a concrete offer converts. If those four are true, the next phase is worth building. If they are not, the plan has done its job by failing cheaply.

The plan therefore asks for one thing: permission to build the digital loop and test it with twenty people. Not a marketplace, not a national launch, not a large budget. A small, reversible experiment, which is exactly what the product asks its users to run.

20	4	1
people in the first mission pilot	conditions that must be true to continue	decision the product exists to make easier

APPENDIX A

Interview Guide

Semi-structured, 35–40 minutes, conducted by two team members. The guide is a sequence of prompts, not a script.

1. Tell me about a personal ambition or way of living you have thought about but never tried.
2. When did you last think about it? What triggered the thought?
3. What have you done so far to explore it, if anything?
4. What makes it difficult to try? Please describe a recent, concrete example.
5. What tools, people, communities, courses or services have you used instead?
6. What would make you trust, or distrust, an app that asks about your ambitions?
7. Which would be most useful: reflecting on the past, comparing possible futures, observing someone else's routine, or trying a short experiment? Why?
8. What would a useful outcome look like, even if you did not make a major change?
9. What information would you not want the app to store?
10. What would make you return after the first session?

> **INTERVIEW DISCIPLINE**
>
> Do not describe the product before question 7. Do not ask "would you use this?". Record behaviour and language, not enthusiasm. Two team members attend: one leads, one captures verbatim quotes and notes where the participant hesitated.

APPENDIX B

Assumptions and Market Model

Every number that drives a conclusion is listed here with its basis and the test that could prove it wrong.

ID	ASSUMPTION	VALUE USED	BASIS	TEST
A1	The need recurs without prompting	18% (ages 40–55)	Planning assumption	Problem interviews
A2	Users complete the first session	60%	Planning assumption	Usability test
A3	Scenarios feel personal	4 of 5 testers	Planning assumption	Concept test
A4	Paid conversion at £8.99	3%	Planning assumption	Paywall test
A5	D30 retention	30%	Planning assumption	Closed beta
A6	Hosts can be screened affordably	£40 per host	Planning assumption	Controlled pilot
A7	Partner-led CAC	Below £40	Channel hypothesis	90-day test
A8	AI cost per monthly active user	Below £0.20	Vendor estimates	Monthly cost report

Table 12. Assumption register. A change to A1 moves the market size; a change to A4 moves the break-even point.

MARKET MODEL ARITHMETIC

UK adults aged 40–55: **15.2 million**. Derived from the ONS mid-2024 age structure for England, using the 40–44, 45–49 and 50–54 bands plus half of the 55–59 band, then scaled to the UK population [11]. The calculation is shown so that the estimate can be checked against the published age structure.

TAM 15.2m × 18% (A1) = **2.74m** adults who recognise the need. SAM 2.74m × 40% app willingness = **1.10m** who will use an app. SOM **40,000** MAU by Year 3 = 3.6% of SAM.

Contribution per MAU = conversion × £8.99 × 0.85 − £0.11. Break-even MAU = £2,000 ÷ (conversion × £8.99 × 0.85 − £0.11). At 2%: 46,700; at 3%: 16,800; at 5%: 7,350.

> **WHAT WOULD CHANGE THE ANSWER**
>
> If A1 falls from 18% to 9%, the SAM halves to about 550,000 and the Year 3 target becomes 7.3% of the serviceable market, which is much harder to defend. If A4 falls from 3% to 2%, break-even rises to about 46,700 MAU. Those two assumptions are the first things the research must test.

APPENDIX C

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Sources were accessed in October 2026. Product descriptions and policies change; verify before submission.

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